India' to it, thus making the battleground wider. CPI(M) state secretary M.V. Govindan Master criticised Khan for gubernatorial overreach. "Who is supreme in democracy?" he asked. "We, the people. Not the governors, who are mere political nominees. Their role is to safeguard the Constitution and function democratically. But the Kerala governor is acting like a Sangh Parivar agent. We will not allow it."

Khan is no stranger to controversy. Addressing the Indian History Congress session in Kannur in December 2021, he used the occasion to defend the Citizenship (Amendment) Act. The 31-minute ex tempore speech was shouted down by the delegates. Among the protesters was celebrated Left historian Prof. Irfan Habib, who asked the governor not to use the occasion for political rhetoric. Khan later asked the Kannur University V-C Gopinath Raveendran to register a police complaint against the organisers for heckling him during his address. However, after watching the videos, the police refused to frame charges against Prof. Habib. Ever since, Khan has been trying to get his own back at the Left-leaning academic spaces in Kerala.

THE COURTS' QUASHING OF SOME V-C APPOINTMENTS HAS ENCOURAGED KHAN TO MAKE A CASE AGAINST ALL V-Cs

He spotted his opportunity when the Supreme Court quashed the appointment of M.S. Rajasree as the V-C of the APJ Abdul Kalam Technological

UP/ MAINPURI

TACTICAL TRUCE

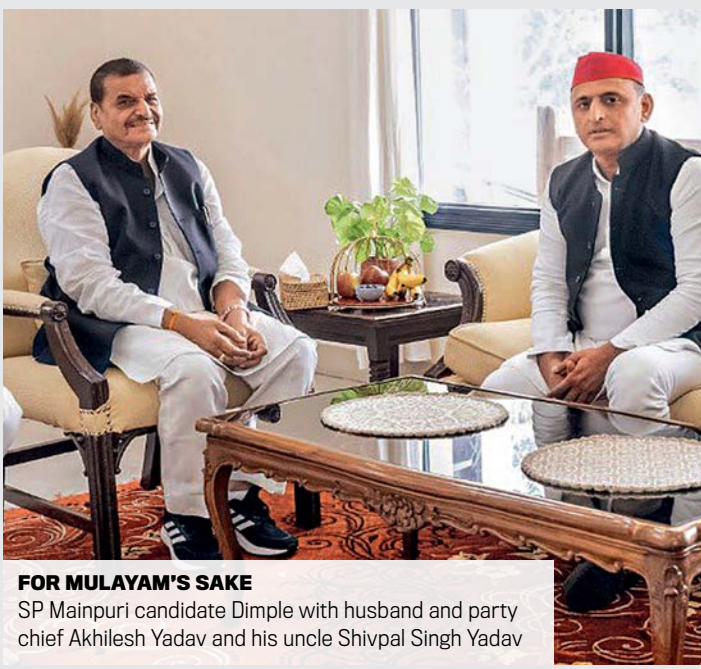
By Prashant Srivastava

In all the din surrounding the assembly elections in Gujarat and Himachal Pradesh, few may have noticed the excitement around the bypoll in Mainpuri, stronghold of the recently departed Samajwadi Party patriarch Mulayam Singh Yadav. Voting for the Lok Sabha seat, necessitated by his demise last month, will be on December 5, and the result announced on December 8.

How crucial is it? Well, crucial enough for hatchets to be buried between Akhilesh Yadav, SP chief and son of Mulayam, and his often-estranged uncle Shivpal. The Yadav clan has come together to throw its weight behind Dimple Yadav, wife of Akhilesh. Mainpuri constituency's borders run close to Mulayam's ancestral village Saifai. More than any wider politics, thus, it has become somewhat of a prestige election, with the SP keen that the seat stay with the family and the BJP seeing it as a fair chance to breach the old Mulayam bastion.

Of course, the SP goes into the election with a huge sympathy wave for 'Netaji'. Enter any village in these parts and everyone will have a Mulayam story to tell you. Prayag Singh, a dhaba owner in Mainpuri's Karhal area, is grateful to him for the four-lane road in front of his dhaba. No other leader cared for his constituency like Netaji, he asserts. The dhaba staff recall how Mulayam had stopped by there sometime in the 1990s for a simple meal of dal-roti. And ever since, he made a pit stop at the dhaba whenever he passed by.

That affection should now transfer to Dimple. Pushpa Devi, a 49-year-old woman from Bewar village, is waiting outside the SP office in Mainpuri where she is supposed to arrive. "We have been a supporter of Netaji's family for the past 25 years," she says. "Now, his bahu is contesting the polls. We will support her." Similarly, Pushpa Yadav, a 23-year-old college student, claims that Netaji had visited her family when she was born. It is only natural then that she campaign for "*bhabhi*", as she calls Dimple.



ANI

FOR MULAYAM'S SAKE
SP Mainpuri candidate Dimple with husband and party chief Akhilesh Yadav and his uncle Shivpal Singh Yadav

Dimple was considered best suited to carry forward Mulayam's legacy in this old fortress, even though Akhilesh's cousins Tej Pratap Yadav and Dharmendra Yadav were also in the fray. Dimple's name was finalised after a series of meetings between Akhilesh and party leaders from the Muslim and Yadav communities in Mainpuri as well as with elders in the Yadav clan in Saifai.

Mainpuri has been a bastion of the SP's first family since 1996 when Mulayam was first elected an MP from here. He contested successfully from the seat three more times—in 2004, 2009 and 2019. Nephew Tej Pratap won the seat in a 2014 bypoll. Despite the apparent Yadav predominance, the caste equations in Mainpuri are interestingly complex. Says a senior SP leader, "Shakya and Thakur votes are crucial here. That's why we recently made